

8 English Lines That Make a Nurse Handover Work

Eight lines for handing over a patient at the end of a shift, each with the reason it works and the weaker version it replaces. Listen, then say each one out loud.

The eight phrases

The same eight lines, now with the pronunciation and the reason each one works. Listen, then say each out loud.

1/8

I will start with the one I am most worried about.

/aɪ wɪl stɑːt wɪð ðə wʌn aɪ æm məʊst 'wɒrɪd ə'baʊt/

ORDERING BY RISK, NOT BY BED NUMBER

INSTEAD OF So, starting with bay one...

Why it works. The person listening is sharpest in the first thirty seconds. Bed order spends that on whoever happens to be nearest the door. Going in order of worry spends it on the patient it matters for.

I have got four for you. I will start with the one I am most worried about.

Sisimulan ko po sa pinaka-inaalala ko.

2/8

Bay three, Mrs Okafor, day two after surgery.

/beɪ θri: 'mɪsɪz ə'kɑ:fɔ: deɪ tu: 'ɑ:ftə 'sɜ:dʒəri/

PLACING THE PATIENT IN ONE BREATH

INSTEAD OF So there is a lady in bay three, she came in on Tuesday I think...

Why it works. Three facts: where, who, how far along. Your colleague needs somewhere to put everything that follows. This builds the shelf before you start loading it.

Bay three, Mrs Okafor, day two after surgery. She is the one I am worried about.

Bay three, Mrs Okafor, pangalawang araw pagkatapos ng operasyon.

3/8

The part of her history you need tonight is this.

/ðə pɑ:t Òv hɜ: 'hɪstəri ju: ni:d tə'naɪt ɪz ðɪs/

SELECTING THE BACKGROUND INSTEAD OF RECITING IT

INSTEAD OF Her background is... (and then all of it)

Why it works. Background is the only step with no natural end. It is where handovers drown. Naming the part that matters stops it, and tells your colleague to listen again.

The part of her history you need tonight is this. She reacted badly to the same drug in March.

Ito po ang bahagi ng kanyang kasaysayan na kailangan ninyo ngayong gabi.

4/8

My assessment is that she is not settling.

/maɪ ə'sɛsmənt ɪz ðæt ʃiː ɪz nɒt 'setlɪŋ/

COMMITTING TO A JUDGEMENT

INSTEAD OF I do not know, she just seems a bit off.

Why it works. You watched her for twelve hours. Your judgement is the most valuable thing you own. Hand over only numbers and the next nurse starts twelve hours behind you.

My assessment is that she is not settling, even though her numbers look fine.

Sa tingin ko po ay hindi siya humuhupa.

5/8

What I need from you this shift is this.

/wɒt aɪ niːd frɒm juː ðɪs ʃɪft ɪz ðɪs/

ASKING, RATHER THAN HOPING

INSTEAD OF Maybe just keep an eye on her.

Why it works. Keep an eye on her is not a task. It cannot be written down. It cannot be handed on again. Nobody can tell you later whether it was done.

What I need from you this shift is this. Two-hourly checks, and call if she is still awake at two.

Ito po ang kailangan ko sa inyo ngayong shift.

6/8

I have not managed to do her four o'clock checks.

/aɪ hæv nɒt 'mænɪdʒd tuː duː hɜː fɔː ə'klɒk tʃeks/

NAMING THE GAP OUT LOUD

INSTEAD OF Yes, everything is done.

Why it works. The job you name becomes theirs. The job you leave unsaid stays yours, and stays undone. Saying it costs four seconds. Nobody was ever thought less of for it.

I have not managed to do her four o'clock checks. They are still outstanding.

Hindi ko po nagawa ang alas-kuwatro niyang checks.

7/8

If her pain goes above six, she needs a doctor, not more tablets.

/ɪf hɜː peɪn ɡəʊz ə'bʌv sɪks ʃiː niːdz ə 'dɒktə nɒt moː 'tæblɪts/

A TRIGGER AND AN ACTION, TOGETHER

INSTEAD OF Call someone if she gets worse.

Why it works. Worse is not a number. Two nurses will draw that line in two different places. Give a trigger they can measure, and the action that goes with it.

If her pain goes above six, she needs a doctor, not more tablets.

Kung lalampas sa anim ang sakit niya, kailangan niya ng doktor.

8/8

She is yours from now. What do you need from me before I go?

/ʃi: ɪz jɔ:z frəm naʊ wɒt du: ju: ni:d frəm mi: bɪ'fɔ: aɪ ɡəʊ/

MAKING THE TRANSFER EXPLICIT

INSTEAD OF Okay, I think that is everything.

Why it works. A handover fails at the seam. Until somebody says it out loud, both nurses can walk away believing the other one is still watching. Saying it also opens the last door for a question.

She is yours from now. What do you need from me before I go?

Sa inyo na po siya mula ngayon. May kailangan pa po ba kayo sa akin?

The steps

This is the sequence. It does not change.



Situation · Background · Assessment · Recommendation

Four steps. If you remember nothing else at the end of a shift, remember that order. A colleague who is given a place, a reason, a judgement and a task can take the patient from you completely.

Now you produce it

Write your answer first, then compare. Retrieving the phrase from a situation is what moves it into the language you can actually use under pressure. There is more than one right answer.

1. You have four patients and three minutes. Open the handover.

I will start with the one I am most worried about.

The person listening is sharpest in the first thirty seconds. Bed order spends that on whoever happens to be nearest the door. Going in order of worry spends it on the patient it matters for.

2. You have said you are worried about her. Now place her.

Bay three, Mrs Okafor, day two after surgery.

Three facts: where, who, how far along. Your colleague needs somewhere to put everything that follows. This builds the shelf before you start loading it.

3. Her notes run to six pages and one line of it matters tonight.

The part of her history you need tonight is this.

Background is the only step with no natural end. It is where handovers drown. Naming the part that matters stops it, and tells your colleague to listen again.

4. Every observation is normal and you still think something is wrong.

My assessment is that she is not settling.

You watched her for twelve hours. Your judgement is the most valuable thing you own. Hand over only numbers and the next nurse starts twelve hours behind you.

5. You want two-hourly checks. Ask for them so they get done.

What I need from you this shift is this.

Keep an eye on her is not a task. It cannot be written down. It cannot be handed on again. Nobody can tell you later whether it was done.

6. You ran out of time and her four o'clock checks are not done.

I have not managed to do her four o'clock checks.

The job you name becomes theirs. The job you leave unsaid stays yours, and stays undone. Saying it costs four seconds. Nobody was ever thought less of for it.

7. You need them to call a doctor — but only at the right moment.

If her pain goes above six, she needs a doctor, not more tablets.

Worse is not a number. Two nurses will draw that line in two different places. Give a trigger they can measure, and the action that goes with it.

8. You are about to walk out of the door.

She is yours from now. What do you need from me before I go?

A handover fails at the seam. Until somebody says it out loud, both nurses can walk away believing the other one is still watching. Saying it also opens the last door for a question.

Come back to this

Two situations, on the two days the research says matter. Say the phrase out loud before you look at the list again.

3/day **Day 3**

Three days ago you learned the four steps: situation, background, assessment, recommendation. New situation. You are handing over to someone far more senior than you, and you can feel yourself shortening everything. Which of the four steps do people cut first under that pressure, and which sentence would you make sure you still said?

7/day

Day 7

One week in. This is the one people get wrong. You are receiving a handover, not giving one, and it is coming at you as one long unordered stream. Two lines from this lesson work from the other side. Can you remember which, and how you would ask without sounding as if you are testing them?

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